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Finfluencers as Financial Education Tools: Comparing Learning Experience and Outcomes with Institutional Resources

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Submission date: 08/09/2026

Finfluencers as Financial Education Tools: Comparing Learning Experience and Outcomes with Institutional Resources

1. Introduction

Financial literacy is essential for informed financial decisions and well-being. Young people increasingly encounter financial information beyond traditional educational settings, particularly through social media. Financial influencers, or "finfluencers," have become prominent sources of financial information [6], [8]. Their accessible content may make financial topics more approachable, although accuracy, educational value, and reliability can vary because it is not subject to the same standards as institutional resources [6], [8], [9].

This issue is particularly relevant in Spain. PISA 2022 found that 17% of Spanish students did not reach the baseline level of financial literacy, while fewer than one in five reported having learned and still knowing concepts such as diversification or return on investment [1]. As young people encounter financial decisions online, the quality of this information may influence how effectively they understand and evaluate financial choices.

Although traditional institutional resources and finfluencers provide financial information, it remains unclear whether they produce comparable immediate learning outcomes or different learning experiences. Existing research has examined these sources and their risks, but limited evidence directly compares them as learning tools [10], [11]. The problem is not simply whether young people use finfluencers, but whether their content can function as a credible learning tool compared with an institutional resource.

Therefore, this study will compare both resources on the same topic, alongside an analysis of 100 finfluencer videos. It will examine financial accuracy, educational value, reliability, immediate learning outcomes, and learning experience to determine whether finfluencers could credibly complement established approaches to youth financial education.

2. Existing Literature

Financial literacy plays an important role in financial decision-making and well-being. Lusardi and Mitchell [4] established its economic importance, while the OECD/INFE [5] defines it through financial knowledge, attitudes, and behaviors. Formal financial education has traditionally been delivered through schools, structured settings, and families [2]. Kaiser and Menkhoff [7] found that school-based financial education improves financial knowledge, while Bover, Hospido, and Villanueva [3] found improvements in students' financial knowledge and saving choices in Spain. Together, this literature establishes the importance of financial literacy and structured educational interventions.

Financial learning also occurs outside formal education. PISA 2022 [1] shows that young people's financial literacy is associated with different learning opportunities and experiences. However, formal education can face challenges such as limited motivation and environmental influences [2], while family financial habits are associated with young people's financial

behaviors [1], [2]. As young people increasingly encounter financial information through digital platforms, understanding whether these environments support financial literacy matters.

Social media has created new financial information channels through financial influencers, or finfluencers. Mölders et al. [6] found that finfluencers can contribute to retail investor engagement and financial literacy, while Hackl and Enzminger [9] found that perceptions of their content may depend on communicator and audience characteristics. Hii and Ong [12] found that source characteristics, accuracy, and informational value are associated with followers' responses. However, the OECD [8], [10] identifies concerns including misleading information, inappropriate recommendations, insufficient risk disclosure, and difficulties assessing influencers' expertise. Gerritsen and de Regt [11] further found that financial influencers' recommendations can expose consumers to financial risks. Thus, existing literature presents a clear tension: finfluencers may increase accessibility and engagement, but their educational reliability cannot be assumed.

This tension reveals the central gap addressed by this study. Formal education offers structured guidance [2], whereas digital financial content may provide greater accessibility and engagement [6], [12]. However, limited studies have directly compared finfluencer-based and institutional resources as learning tools under standardized conditions. Existing research therefore provides evidence about financial education, finfluencer content, and consumer risks, but does not sufficiently establish how the two approaches compare when students learn the same financial concept through comparable resources.

The present study addresses this gap through an analysis of 100 finfluencer videos and an exploratory experiment comparing a finfluencer-based resource with an institutional resource covering the same topic. This design connects information quality with learning outcomes and learner experience, testing whether accessibility and engagement correspond with educational value in this context.

3. Research Questions

The study examines finfluencer content quality and differences in immediate learning outcomes and reported learning experience. The questions separate three related issues: the quality of the information, the learning outcome it supports, and the experience of learning from it.

22 Main Research Question. To what extent do finfluencer-based and institutional financial education resources differ as learning tools in terms of immediate learning outcomes and reported learning experience among high-school students aged 16–18?

RQ1. To what extent do selected finfluencer videos demonstrate financial accuracy, risk disclosure, use of supporting evidence, educational value, and overall reliability?

RQ2. To what extent do immediate learning outcomes differ between participants using a finfluencer-based resource and those using an institutional resource?

RQ3. To what extent does reported learning experience differ between participants using a finfluencer-based resource and those using an institutional resource?

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4. Methodology

4.1 Research Design

This study will use a mixed, two-part design combining content analysis of finfluencer videos with a two-condition randomized experiment. The content analysis will evaluate the quality and reliability of financial information available through finfluencers, while the experiment will compare a finfluencer-based resource with an institutional resource in terms of immediate learning outcomes and reported learning experience. Combining these methods allows the study to examine both what financial content communicates and how students learn from comparable resources.

4.2 Sampling and Participants

Participants will be high-school students aged 16–18 recruited from schools that have granted permission for the study. Because the pool of eligible students in my area is limited, the study will recruit the largest feasible number. Participants who provide informed consent and complete the procedure will be randomly allocated through the web-based platform to either the Finfluencer or Institutional condition. Random allocation will reduce systematic differences between groups and strengthen comparability. Participants' prior knowledge of the topic will also be collected to contextualize differences in immediate learning outcomes.

4.3 Instruments and Materials

For content analysis, 100 videos from 10 selected financial influencers, 10 per influencer, will be evaluated using a researcher-designed 1–5 rubric covering seven dimensions: financial accuracy, risk disclosure, supporting data and sources, promotion of quick wealth, entertainment value, educational value, and overall reliability. Quick-wealth promotion will be reverse-scored so higher scores consistently represent stronger educational quality. Influencers must have at least one million TikTok followers, produce financial content, and be active creators. Videos will be selected using predefined criteria to reduce selection bias.

For the experiment, participants will receive either a finfluencer video or an institutional BBVA article covering Risk and Portfolio Diversification. This topic was selected because understanding risk and diversification is relevant to young people approaching adulthood and increasingly making financial decisions involving saving and investing [1]. Both resources will address the same concept and comparable learning objectives under the same platform and time constraints. Participants will complete a practical activity scored out of 7, measuring immediate learning through application of risk and diversification concepts, followed by a 1–5 Likert-scale survey measuring reported learning experience.

4.4 Experimental Procedure

The experiment will follow four stages: allocation, learning, practical assessment, and learning-experience assessment. Both conditions will receive identical instructions, structure, and timing for 50 minutes: 20 minutes for the learning resource, 20 minutes for the practical activity, and 10 minutes for the survey.

The assigned resource will be the primary experimental difference; the topic, learning objectives, instructions, timing, activity, and survey will remain consistent. This standardization will reduce procedural differences and allow a clearer comparison of the two learning resources.

4.5 Data Analysis

Data will come from the practical activity, post-learning survey, and content-analysis rubric. Results will be analyzed descriptively. Practical scores will be summarized using mean, median, minimum, maximum, and standard deviation for each condition. Survey responses will use the 1–5 Likert scale, with mean scores calculated across ten items covering understanding, enjoyment, interest, concentration and engagement, time appropriateness, retention, simplification of complex topics, workload, willingness to use similar resources, and overall learning experience. Differences will be examined descriptively to identify patterns within the sample rather than make population-level causal claims. Although we will seek the largest feasible sample, the limited local student population makes inferential tests such as ANOVA inappropriate for the study's scope.

The seven criteria will be applied consistently to all 100 videos, allowing comparison across creators. Findings will focus on sample-level patterns and will not be generalized to all finfluencers without further evidence.

4.6 Methodological Consistency and Ethical Considerations

Consistency will be supported by using the same topic, learning objectives, activity, survey, Likert scale, instructions, and experimental structure across groups. Random allocation will strengthen comparability, while standardized scoring and the predefined rubric will improve consistency. For the content analysis, scores, video selection criteria, supporting evidence, and coding decisions will be documented in Excel to reduce subjectivity and ensure transparency.

Participation will be voluntary, with informed consent obtained before data collection. Participants will be informed of the study's purpose, procedures, and right to withdraw. Responses will be anonymous, confidential, and used solely for academic purposes.

5. Expected Outcomes

Participants in the Finfluencer condition are expected to report a more positive learning experience, consistent with the accessibility and engagement associated with financial content on social media [6], [9], while both conditions are expected to produce comparable immediate

learning outcomes. The content analysis is expected to identify variation among creators in financial accuracy, risk disclosure, supporting evidence, educational value, reliability, and entertainment value [6], [8], [9], [12]. The study will not assume that greater engagement necessarily translates into stronger learning outcomes.

6. Limitations

The small sample may limit generalizability, while immediate assessment will not capture long-term retention. Self-reported learning experience may reflect subjective perceptions, and researcher judgment remains unavoidable despite predefined criteria. Prior knowledge may influence performance; familiarity with the topic will be assessed beforehand but cannot be fully controlled. Comparing one finfluencer video with one institutional resource limits conclusions beyond the materials, while audiovisual and text-based formats may affect learning experience. Findings will therefore be interpreted as evidence about the resources and conditions examined, not a definitive judgment about all finfluencers or institutional resources.

7. Conclusion

This study will examine whether finfluencers can complement institutional resources in youth financial education. By combining a literature review, content analysis, and exploratory experiment, it will assess finfluencer content quality and compare immediate learning outcomes and reported learning experience with an institutional resource. The study aims to provide evidence on how financial education can adapt to changing ways young people encounter information. Rather than assuming either approach is superior, it seeks to identify their strengths and when digital content can genuinely support learning. Ultimately, the research aims to help young people understand, question, and use financial information responsibly when making decisions that shape their futures.

8. Potential Impact

This research aims to provide preliminary evidence on how financial education can adapt to an increasingly digital environment. By examining finfluencer content and comparing it with an institutional resource, it will identify their strengths and potential to complement established approaches.

The findings will inform the refinement of ECIF Ignite, a 15-session financial education program designed to provide young people with essential financial knowledge before adulthood. Insights into accessibility, learning experience, and educational value will support the integration of digital and traditional approaches while maintaining educational reliability.

The research will translate evidence into practical improvements. Rather than simply determining whether one format performs better, it will help young people navigate an environment where financial information is abundant, accessible, and difficult to evaluate. By connecting research with ECIF Ignite, the study aims to help young people become not only more informed, but more critical and confident in using financial information responsibly.

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